

“With both parents working and schools usually open for only 190 of the 365 days, how is a child to spend time?” ARUN KAPUR Director, Vasant Valley School



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Spends two hours each on video games and TV

He is the only child of his parents. A Standard VI student, he has a Wii with the latest accessories, a Play Station, and a television in his room. He also uses the Internet as an aid in homework and to play online games. He scores well so his parents find it difficult to find fault with him on the issue. His mother Manju sometimes tries to get a feel of her child's new world and is left bewildered when she finds nasty messages in his mailbox.

Digital Dos and Don'ts

Instead of being grateful for these digital nannies, pay attention to their passports to freedom

- Don't keep the computer in the child's bedroom. Keep it in a central location from where you can keep an eye on the sites the child visits and the games he plays.
- Spend quality time with the child every day so that he doesn't feel the need to watch TV or switch on the computer. Try simple things like going to the park or even the market.
- Keep a tab on the child's mobile phone bills and the numbers he calls repeatedly. You should know your child's friends.
- Avoid fights at home. Call guests home so that your child learns to mingle with the family and not be solitary.
- Maintain a deadline for sleeping, such as 10 p.m., and enforce it. Don't allow any activity, not even studying, after that.
- Watch TV together as a family; play computer games as a collective activity; even surf the Net together.
- Encourage outdoor play, specifically sports. Ensure enough indoor alternatives such as chess, carrom, Scrabble or Monopoly.
- Develop hobbies such as singing, drawing, or even cooking.
- Voluntarily cut down on your TV time and set an example for children by reading, visiting museums, going on hikes, playing sports or even doing social work.
- Communicate with children on a regular basis to keep tabs on their behaviour in school and on the playground.

34% children who surf the Net listed multiplayer online games as their favourite activity.

19% children have made a friend online who they have never met. Orkut is the third most-visited website after Google and Yahoo.

Source: Cartoon Network's New Generations 2009 surveyed 7,874 respondents comprising 3,431 children aged 7 to 14, 3,431 parents of children aged 7 to 14 and 1,012 parents of children aged 4 to 6 across 15 cities.

with Apollo Hospital, Delhi, says parents need to communicate with their children, keeping in mind their need for privacy. "They need to educate themselves of their children's world," he says. "Inculcate good values and trust them. Talk frankly, don't do extreme things like installing a spy cam to keep tabs." It's as Zarina Mehta, CEO, UTV Bindaas, which airs *Dadagiri*, points out: "Like *Shin Chan* for younger children, our channel is all about *masti* with morals. I am aware 10-14-year-olds watch Bindaas, but my target group is older." Ashish Patil of MTV, which airs *Roadies* and *Splitsville*, echoes this and adds, "Mainstream entertainment shows anyway have more 'unlicensed thrills'." They're trying to go easy on the abuse in *Roadies 7.0*. Parents have to watch what their children watch.

Indeed, as Dr N. Shalini, Consultant Psychiatrist, Mind Focus, Psychiatric Services and Research Foundation, Chennai, puts it, every generation finds its own way to network. What would be done through cafes and on playgrounds is done on computers. "Even before Facebook and Orkut, scores of children have wasted their

prime of their youth, just sitting and talking around street corners." Just like the mothers of yesteryear exercised their iron wills to rescue their children from such street corner world, today's parents are doing their best to wean their kids from the virtual world. And surprisingly, the best way to do this is the age-old grandma's formula of reward and punishment. The punishments are parental time-out (avoiding eye contact with children) and denying privileges (such as switching off television, retracting treats or postponing gifts) and the rewards are more play time, appreciation, especially in front of others, and strong encouragement.

But all this will happen only if there is a public debate over what is being considered a private universe. If parents, instead of worshipping at the altar of technology, begin to question some of the values being generated by the games or television and provide healthier options. Technology has to be used with wisdom. As Steve Case, forum chairman of AOL, once said, cannot be a substitute for parenting.

with inputs from Nirmala Ravindran, Amitabh Srivastava, Abhijit Dasgupta and Mahalingam Ponnusamy